

the sight of pre-teens sitting in a room doing all of that over an app isn't uncommon. In fact, even the excitement of engaging with friends while playing video games is being slowly replaced by services like Twitch, which allow viewers to just watch other people playing the game.

But it's lazy to just wash our hands of the problem and presume that today's kids are a different species, who are destined to be different than their parents. This isn't just another example of the generation gap, but the result of parental complacency. After all, today's adults too once had their tryst with technology, even if it was more analogue in form – such as a bicycle – but rarely, if ever, did kids ride off to other cities while their parents just sat at home uncaring. The only difference with technology today is that it brings the big bad world right onto a screen that's staring your child in the face.

Kids are natural explorers and gravitate to newer technology, while for most adults technology adaptation is an acquired skill. Even the term “digital native” is nearly antiquated due to the natural propensity of children acquiring technological proficiency faster than adults. This was proven in a case study from Tufts University and the MIT Media Lab, when solar-powered tablets were given out to village children in Ethiopia. Within 20 minutes of being given these devices, the children in this village, who hadn't experienced any electricity or literacy, were able to begin using the device without any help. And in less than a week they were using 47 apps. The “digital native” is in all of us, but only when we're children; it's the growing up that makes us estranged from our native roots of open learning.

This gap in perceptions is what adults need to understand when dealing with digital natives – that their exposure and vulnerability to the real world is far more fragile than the earlier generation's. The balancing act between the risks and advantages of new technology falls on the responsible shoulders of adults, and a proactive approach instead of a passive-reactive approach is necessary. Each successive generation will always have a higher aptitude towards technology, but it's in the hands (and wallets) of adults as to how much and how often they exploit it. Opening up to one's own level of accountability is the first and most critical step, in ensuring the proper use of technology by our children.

Kids on the Open Web

Fear is never a good motivator for learning, but evolutionarily it's an effective one. And when it comes to children on the web, there's much to fear. But